red

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31703251.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Hurt/Comfort, Like brief touches of sex but that's not the point, Healing, Recovery, Canon Compliant, Safeword Use, Aftercare, Post-Canon

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Part 34 of Outside of the War - She-ra canon stories

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra has things she likes during sex, but she also has trauma. Sometimes the two dont get along. Sometimes she needs to be in control to feel safe and other times she thinks that she can handle letting Adora take the wheel. She isnt always right about when that is, though.
Or, in which Catra has a panic attack during sex.

Notes

CW: This is going to involve a "random" panic attack during sex and the fallout of that, but Catra doesnt have a full episode or flashback. It's mostly about panic and aftercare. Read at your own discretion.
This is set after the other half of you (exposure therapy). You absolutely dont need to read that to understand this, but if you want to see Catra's first time with She-ra, that's the fic.
Their safe words were established in to have & hold, but it's red for stop, pink for slow, and blue for go.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra likes to be held during sex. It does a lot for her to feel Adora's arms wrapped around her, her hands strong and confident. It is comforting to be surrounded by someone she trusts. It is grounding when a part of her mind that she can't control starts telling her that she is too vulnerable, too exposed – that she should be *fighting*. She likes to be held, and she likes it when they are close together, Adora at her back, or laid out beneath her, or draping over her as a blanket of security.

Catra *knows* she likes this. Adora is above her, nuzzling into the top of her head and pressing light kisses against her ears. Her hands are strong on Catra, holding her steady as Adora thrusts her hips up, driving the strap in at a smooth pace. It's everything that Catra usually likes, She-ra's strong hands on her, cradling her like she is something precious. Despite being excited by this when Adora proposed it initially, her breath is starting to get just a little too quick as anxiety sparks in her chest.

She has been conflicted about She-ra in the past. It took being around Adora while she was transformed a number of times before she was comfortable with Adora bringing She-ra out for something like this. There are bad memories surrounding She-ra, though less so in this new form. Even with the new appearance, she has a magical aura about her, glowing with light and warmth. It is a far cry from the electric crackle of magic that Catra grew up being hurt by, but some days it isn't different *enough*.

Today isn't one of those days. Today the warmth of Adora's magic – of her *love* – is pouring out of her and soaking into Catra's fur, helping her relax in her arms. Adora would never touch her as She-ra on a day when her magic was making Catra uneasy, but Catra still needs the help relaxing. She is turned on, but for some reason her heart is rattling in her chest with every thrust as she buries her face in She-ra's neck.

Adora is standing, because she got that stupid cocky swagger to her that drives Catra wild and said that she bet that she could easily fuck

Catra standing up as She-ra. Catra's tail had immediately thudded against the side of the bed with eager anticipation, her entire body lighting up at the idea. They've had sex against the wall as She-ra, but this is different – Adora is standing beside the bed, leaning on nothing as she cradles Catra against her and thrusts into her.

Catra feels her ears pin back and a soft whimper escapes her as Adora thrusts in just right. It feels *good*. Adora is all around her, safe and warm. Catra is *not* being suffocated right now. She doesn't know what weird conflict her body is going through, but she would like it to stop so she can just enjoy herself. She nudges her nose up against Adora's pulse point, breathing deep and focusing on her scent. It's different as She-ra, but it still has the essence of Adora to it that causes Catra's fur to lie flat again.

Safe. Adora is holding her up, but Catra is still safe. She-ra's arms would never give out, and Adora would never drop her. She gets a few seconds of relaxing into the steady press of the toy before the anxious buzz starts in her chest again. Fuck, why is this *happening*? She wants to do this. She likes this. She's enjoying Adora surrounding her. Why does her body have to fight her at this moment? Adora wanted to take care of her and - twenty minutes ago, at least - Catra wanted to let her. Her body seems to have other ideas now.

Adora's hands shift on her. She is changing her grip, but Catra's heart *trips* and it's all over. She whimpers, not with pleasure, but with outright *fear* as the sensation pours through her entire body, her breath coming fast. In an instant, all the silent assurances she was telling herself fly out the window. She is flying, falling, Adora *dropped her*. Catra writhes, twisting and fighting to get her feet under her before she hits the ground as she gasps for air, her eyes screwing up as she fights the hands holding her down, forcing her still, subjugating her, *drowning* her-

"Red," rings out clear through the violent twist as Catra scrambles to fight her way free and lands on something soft. Her entire body stills, her heart *pounding* as her limbs quiver with anxiety. She is on the

ground- no, the bed. Her entire body curls into the sheets, gripping them tightly as the magic aura in the room dissipates. She didnt speak –she isnt capable of it, still in the throes of a panic attack. She whimpers in the midst of her gasps, trembling with unreasonable fear like a fucking *kitten*.

t' s okay. Im right here. Y oure safe. Iwont hurt you,"Adora promises, her voice pitched low and radiating from somewhere nearby. Catra buries her face in the sheets, trying to suffocate herself so she stops fucking *gasping*. She is fine. Adora didnt drop her , she just put her down on the bed when Catra freaked out for absolutely no reason.

s it okay to touch you?"Adora asks. Catra can hear the tremors of anxiety in her voice, but Adora is trying to stay steady and help her through it. Catra is too busy trying to hold her breath and reset the desperate expansion and contraction of her ribs to reply. She lashes her tail, thudding against something she hopes is Adora and doing her best to wrap around it as her claws cling into the sheets.

Adora takes the hint. A single hand runs down her back, a gentle point of contact without being suffocating. Catra is out of air. Shakily, she blows out the remainder of her breath and takes in another one. Despite the way her body is still quivering, crystals of icy fear pricking at all her limbs and threatening to numb her entirely, she doesnt begin gasping again. She manages to draw in a few uneven breaths.

With some air in her body again, she forces herself up and flings herself in Adora's direction without even looking. Adora catches her –of course she does, she would never *drop Catra*, that's ridiculous. Adora wraps her arms around Catra, holding her close against her chest as Catra seeks out her pulse point and buries herself in Adora's scent, unadulterated by magic. A trembling relief begins to wash through her body as Adora gathers her up and cautiously climbs into the bed beside her.

t's safe. You're going to be alright," Adora promises her, concern still in her voice, but there is relief there too as she lays down and drapes Catra over her chest. Catra hasn't opened her eyes. She can't. She can't face what just happened. She is relieved that Adora is still dressed in the pants and shirt she was wearing before they started *posturing* at each other and Adora transformed. She doesn't know what happened to the strap while she was panicking, but the buckles were set to accommodate She-ra's size, so it probably slipped off when Adora transformed back.

She has Adora pinned beneath her, a comforting presence she can curl into. She isn't trapped or being held down. She could flee if she wanted to, but she doesn't. She feels safe now. She doesn't have to remind herself that this is okay because it's Adora and she would never hurt her – she just knows that. For several long moments, Catra just breathes her girlfriend in as Adora pets down her back and murmurs that it's going to be okay, she's *safe*. Residual trembles and shocks work through Catra's body as her system clears out the adrenaline.

I'm sorry," Catra eventually manages to mumble against Adora's neck. Adora's hand on her back freezes. After a long moment in which Catra can *feel* Adora's heart thudding in her chest, she shifts the hand up to gently – *so* gently, like Catra is made of shattered glass that threatens to cut her – squeeze at the back of Catra's neck. She can hardly feel it on her scruff, but she knows that Adora is trying to encourage her to lift her head.

"There's nothing to apologize for. Are you up to looking at me?" Adora asks her, her voice soft and coaxing. Catra swallows and nods. She is, but she is also drained after that.

"On our sides," she murmurs in response. She isn't up to moving, but she doesn't have to. Adora tucks Catra carefully against her chest and rolls them over so Catra can rest her cheek against the pillow. Catra rubs against it, breathing in their mixed scents in the fabric as Adora shifts just far enough away to gaze at her where she also has

her head rested on the pillow. Catra takes a deep breath and finally opens her eyes.

Adora's brow is creased with concern, but relief floods her eyes as their gaze finally meet. She offers Catra a gentle smile, reaching up to stroke her cheek. Catra can hear her heartbeat pounding. She leaves her eyes slit, turning her cheek into Adora's touch and assuring herself that Adora isn't upset with her. She *knew* that she wouldn't be, but-

But she also knows that Adora wouldn't drop her. She also knows Adora is safe. She also knows there is no reason to ever panic during sex with Adora, because Adora will always take care of her and stop if Catra asks her to. Adora called stop *for* her when she couldn't speak. Catra knows all this, but logic and years of trauma don't always mix. She blows out a shaking breath as Adora gazes at her with nothing but love.

"There's my girl," Adora murmurs, her voice soft and affectionate. Catra manages a soft *prbbt*, nudging into the touch as her heartbeat slows down. Adora's expression is nothing but loving and encouraging as she gently pets Catra, grounding her and offering affection. "It's alright. I'll give you anything you need," Adora promises her in a whisper. Catra shivers, pressing a little closer. Adora shifts so she can slide her other arm beneath Catra and pull her close against her chest.

Catra cuddles against her. She can do that now without feeling trapped and held down. It was a bad moment, but her body is calming again, sinking into Adora's warmth. It helps that her hands are smaller now, no longer capable of encircling Catra's waist easily between the two of them. In a physical fight, Catra has a much better chance against Adora than She-ra. Not that it would ever come to that, but her brain forgot that detail for a minute.

Adora cradles her close, murmuring those assurances without asking Catra any questions. She promises her that she'll do whatever she needs right now, but she doesn't ask Catra what that is

when she isn't up to answering it quite yet. Catra doesn't really *need* anything anyway. Adora is soft and assuring, and that is what ultimately helps her body calm down and relax again.

Catra shivers lightly in the sheets, pressing closer as a shift in the air ruffles her fur. She is painfully aware that she is naked, no longer turned on but her thighs still damp from what they were doing before her panic. It feels weird to just stop in the middle of sex, but that wasn't the first time they have had to, even if it was never for that reason. They have been interrupted by duties, or getting caught messing around where they shouldn't have, and once even by Catra having a full-blown episode, but this was...needless.

A voice in her head that sounds suspiciously like Perfuma reminds Catra that she needed to stop and this is what happens when she doesn't listen to her own needs. She buries her face in Adora' s neck again, her ears pinning back to the sides of her head. Adora shushes her gently, murmuring *I've got you* as Catra clings tightly against her front.

"Do you want clothes?" Adora asks, her voice soft as she pets gently down Catra's back. Catra draws in a breath. That means Adora getting up and pulling away from her, but the answer is undoubtedly yes. She nods against Adora's neck.

"Pajamas. And the bathroom," she murmurs. She isn't putting back on her clothes from before, crumpled on the floor beside the bed. They are dusty from her earlier visit to the construction site that has replaced the Fright Zone as they work on rebuilding the scorpioni kingdom. It' s not ideal for crawling into bed and never leaving it.

"Okay . I'll walk you," Adora replies, her voice soft as she tucks her head down to kiss the top of Catra's head. Catra manages a gentle rumble as Adora shifts and lifts them both into an upright sitting position. Catra can absolutely walk *herself* to the bathroom, but she isn't going to. It helps calm her heart to have Adora pull her to her feet and walk her to the bathroom with an arm around her waist.

Adora presses a gentle kiss to her forehead when they reach it, squeezing Catra for a moment before dropping her arm around her .

"I'll get clothes. I'm right outside," Adora assures her . Catra nods, taking a shaking step forward on her own.

"I know ," she returns, her own voice quiet before she slips into the bathroom. Her panicked delirium is gone and she knows Adora is right here for her, she just lost sight of that for a moment in the face of hands all around her. For a second, they went from holding her up to holding her *down*, forcing her below green liquid.

Catra shivers as she uses the bathroom and cleans herself up. She doesn't want to feel like she just had sex. She wants to be clean and dry, anything sexual totally removed from terrified memories like that. When she is drying her hands, she flicks her ears, straining for the door and making out the sounds of Adora shifting outside of it. Catra heard the closet door a few moments ago.

When she opens the bathroom door, Adora is waiting on the other side, holding a small stack of clothes. She smiles encouragingly at Catra, handing her the clothes one at a time so Catra can pull each garment on. Once she is fully dressed, she draws in a deep breath and blows it back out. Adora is nothing but encouraging, raising her arms when Catra steps closer and drawing her into a hug.

"I love you," she assures, pressing a soft kiss against the top of Catra's head. Catra's heart skips a beat as she nudges up into the affection. Adora repeats the gesture, kissing the top of her head and then each of her ears in turn.

"Even when I have random panic attacks in the middle of amazing sex?" Catra returns, even though she knows the answer . She didn't realize how badly she needed to hear Adora say it until she did, assuring Catra that it's okay when she slips. She hates her panicked moments, when she reverts back to the scared little girl who only knew how to be hurt and hurt in return. It feels like backsliding, even

if Perfuma assures her it is normal. Catra doesn't want to go back to *being* that way.

"Even then and *always*. I love you," Adora answers, no hesitation in her voice. Catra breathes out a sigh of relief, her chest rumbling slightly as she nuzzles into Adora for a moment more. She casts her mind back to the moment the switch flipped, trying to figure out *why* it all went wrong then, but after a few seconds her thoughts completely derail as she realizes that she had her claws out as she flailed.

She jerks back, grabbing Adora by the biceps and casting her eyes over her frantically as she searches for any signs of injury. Adora startles a little, but she merely offers Catra a reassuring smile as she lets her hands fall away, misinterpreting the sudden movement as Catra needing distance.

"I didn't hurt you, did I?" Catra demands, her eyes finally making their way back up to Adora's face after finding no visible injuries on Adora's body. Adora quickly shakes her head, reaching up and carefully petting down Catra's forearms.

"She-ra, remember? It takes more to hurt her. I'm fine," Adora assures. Catra breathes out another sigh, all her newfound energy sapping away. It wasn't true energy, just adrenaline and worry. She takes a half step forward and sags into Adora's arms, finding herself immediately cradled by Adora's soft hands. "I'm okay. I love you," Adora adds on, a quiet assurance as she cradles Catra close and kisses the base of her ear.

Catra purrs, nuzzling into her. She knows she is safe. She doesn't need Adora to assure her of that now, but Adora's concern makes her heart melt as Adora ushers them back to the bed. They crawl back in together, ending up cuddled together on their sides again as Adora pets through her hair.

"Was there anything I did to trigger it?" Adora asks softly. Catra sighs and shakes her head. She already wondered about that, but no,

Adora didn't do anything wrong. That's what is so *frustrating*; sometimes there is no cause, not really. In this case it was because of Adora's hands holding her up – holding her down, in her mind – but there are plenty of days when they can do that and Catra loves it.

"No. I thought today was a day where it would be fine. I just felt the anxiety building and didn't call pink soon enough," Catra admits, her voice a low rasp. Usually she catches something like this coming and they stop before it becomes a problem. She can call pink and they can talk about it calmly before it becomes an outright *red* situation that drains them both like this. Adora frowns, her entire expression pinching with distress as she shifts her hand in Catra's hair to cup her cheek again.

"It's not your fault. I'm not upset with you," Adora promises her, leaning forward to kiss Catra's forehead. Catra purrs, leaning into the soft touch of Adora's lips. Adora knows her well enough to sense when Catra is beating herself up and that she needs assurance.

Catra startles a little when she feels a soft nudge in the back of her mind. Despite surprising her, it helps her relax, going limp in Adora's arms as Melog approaches the door to their room. They made themselves scarce when she and Adora started flirting, but now they're back and aware that Catra needs them. Melog nudges their door open, startling Adora as it thuds shut behind them. Catra just sighs softly as her space cat shrinks down and jumps into the bed with them.

"I'm okay, buddy," Catra promises them, reaching down to pet Melog as they climb into the gap between her and Adora and look up at her with their wide blue eyes. They mew softly – the sentiment is *you'll be better now I'm here* - as they curl up between the two of them. A smile twitches at Catra lips as she lets her body relax into the mattress. Adora seems a bit more at ease now that she has back up, reaching down to pat Melog's head before she returns to petting through Catra's hair.

"What do you need right now?" Adora asks, now that Catra is actually capable of answering the question. Catra mulls it over for a moment before shaking her head and leaning back into Adora's touch.

"This is perfect," she returns. It really is. She is tired after all the panic and adrenaline, feeling drained in its absence. All she wants is to cuddle into the safety of Adora's arms as Melog curls up with her. She is grateful Melog shrunk down so there aren't two large bodies in the bed with her, crushing her in and making her feel trapped all over again. That may be her usual preferred way to sleep, but it wouldn't help her right now and Melog knows that.

"Okay . . . Is there anything I can do next time to help more?" Adora asks her, her voice curious and maybe a touch hopeful, like she really wants the answer to be yes. Nothing in her tone is accusatory. Catra really wants to immediately shake her head and dismiss it – it isn't *Adora's job* to fix her – but she forces herself to take a breath and think it over.

"Clothes sooner , maybe. Or the sheets to cover me at least. I wasn't up to you pulling away before that. Just ask before trying to cover me or I'll probably panic about being trapped again," Catra decides, looking down at Melog because she can't meet Adora' s eyes as she asks *more* of her. In her periphery , Adora nods, massaging at the base of her ear.

"Okay . I'll always ask if you're in any state to reply ," Adora assures her. Catra just nods. She knows that. It' s what Adora did this time as well. She still needed to hear it. She hates asking for so much, making Adora *give* her so much, but there is nothing she loves more than how readily Adora gives it to her, her words, voice, and hands gentle.

"I uh, do want to do that again. On another day , when I'm feeling better," Catra mutters. She' s conflicted about admitting it. It' s true, but she also needs to say it to assure Adora that she really did nothing wrong, Catra's brain just went in overdrive. At the same time,

it feels like asking even more of Adora, to tell her she wants to try again when it could end the same way. Adora doesnt seem to have the same conflict. She just smiles, shifting her hand to cup Catra' s cheek and leaning in slowly, giving Catra plenty of time to stop her.

"Okay . Tell me when you think you're ready ,"she assures her . For a moment, she just looks at Catra, her eyes shining. "Can Ikiss you?" she breathes, her words soft and breath hot on Catra's face. Catra blushes, nodding jerkily as she lets her eyes slip closed. The kiss is soft, a gentle press of lips before Adora shifts back to merely rest their foreheads together.

Catra sighs, feeling much more content. She focuses on Melog's grounding presence and the gentle care of Adora's touch, all of it assuring her that she is safe and loved. She cant unwrite the pathways in her brain that her trauma hardcoded in, but she can let herself accept care once the moment passes. She wishes she didnt have flashes like this, but they are at least getting better, less intense and less frequent.

"I love you,"she breathes to Adora, because Adora said it earlier and she hates letting it go unanswered. Adora lets out a soft, pleased hum.

"I love you too,"she assures, hugging Catra close. Catra breathes out a slow breath. Yeah, she knows. She may lose sight of it momentarily sometimes, but in moments like this, she knows it without a doubt.

End Notes

f you're interested in more Catra/She-ra, the other half of you is linked above, but Ialso have dancing around the red line and peace in letting go.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!